

Burners Company

Ok boys, check your kit, check your weapons, it's today. You get a pint and a chaser, no more. Let's go

How a crew is hired, kept, bonded, and **Mustered**. Pay rates live on [[Burners Equipment#Hirelings]]. Heart 1+ unlocks Muster and Company slots in [[Burners Adventure Game]].

Two Roles

Role	What they are	Dangerous places	Base Loyalty
Hireling	Day- or week-rate hand	No — camp, wall, town only	6
Retainer	On keep; fights for pay	Yes	7

Loyal is a **tag** applied to a hireling or a retainer after forging a loyal bond. A **loyal** hand gets a **substantial Loyalty bonus (+3)** and, when they hold, **acts loyally** — prioritizes their patron, Blocks for them, stays on their heel. Ordinary retainers put themselves first. Only a Boss's sworn company usually earns the tag in play; a camp hireling can be loyal too (they hold the wall for you, not because of a pay rate alone).

Anyone with coin can hire. Only a **Boss (Heart 1+)** **Musters** — splitting the twelve into physical kit and **Company** seats, and seating today's crew.

XP. Delving retainers take **XP as in OSE** — share the pot with the PCs, keep half of their award — whether Mustering or not. Levels on the Burner XP table (civilization), Sword or Craft only, never above the Boss's level. Hirelings do not delve.

Company Hands (half power)

Hands are not Burners. They have a **track level** and place Approaches in **Sword or Craft only** — never Sorcerie, never Heart, never Muster. Hirelings usually stay at the level they were hired. Retainers climb on XP.

Who plays them.

- **Mustered** (in a Company seat): the **Boss's player** plays and rolls for that hand.
- **Otherwise** (hired but unseated, or hired by a non-Boss): **NPCs** run by the Referee.

Loyalty and Morale stay with the Referee either way.

Everything that scales with level or Approach is halved, round down (see *Manage* for the only round-up):

Piece	Company rule
Traits	2 per track level (half of a Burner's 4)
Signatures	At most [Approach / 2] per Approach — earned in play, never bought
HP	

Piece	Company rule
	Roll 1d6 per track level , then [total / 2] (minimum 1). On level-up: PC-style reroll (keep higher of new total or old+1), then half again.
Fuel level dice / refill	[track level / 2] , minimum 1
Veteran extras	[Sword / 2] extras (Sword 1 → one attack)
Approach rolls	2d6 + [Approach / 2]
Shock and other Approach math	Same half (Shock: 2d6 + [Sword / 2])

Not halved: wages, shares, Muster seats (**1 per hand**), Loyalty, kit on their person. Armor still soaks. Full Wound and Shock once HP is spent.

Manage (Boss Action)

Default: half, always round **down**.

Managed: The Boss spends **their Action** that round to **manage** one **Mustered** hand. Until the next Roll Initiative, that hand uses **half round up** for Approach rolls, Shock, Veteran extras, and Fuel level-die counts in that window. HP on the sheet does not rewrite mid-fight.

- One Action → **one** hand for that round.
- Only a hand you are Mustering.
- Managing again next round costs another Action.

Traits

Job names are Traits, tagged to Sword or Craft. A hand fills their item slots for that work; the Boss outfits upgrades from the purse.

Packbearers carry baggage and keep simple items handy: rope, waterskin, and the like.

Fighting men hold Sword-tagged Traits for preferred arms and kit — spear, arming sword, shield.

Lantern bearers (linkboys, torchbearers) hold *lantern-bearer* or *torchbearer*. Lantern or torches, flint and steel, oil.

Shield bearers hold *shield* / shield-bearer. Chief work: resupplying fighters with fresh boards.

Squires keep weapons ready (“*Squire, my sword!*”). They may help a fighter don armor.

War dogs hold *bite* (and often a thick hide).

Company Seats

Each hand costs **one Company slot**. One person, one seat. Care, violence, and loyalty do not change seat cost — they modify **Loyalty** on Morale checks.

Muster (Heart 1+)

Before a job — in town or at the safehouse — or on any **8-hour sleep**, the Boss **Musters**:

1. Declare the **physical** / **Company** split of the twelve.
2. Seat named hands — **one Company slot each**.
3. Lock the Muster for the run until the next Muster.

Going alone: Muster **0** Company, all twelve physical. Hands wait at home.

Company slots hold **people**, not gear. Kit rides on them; wages, keep, and new gear come from the Boss's purse. On Roll Initiative the Boss adds **one die per Company slot declared** (filled or empty). Those slots never also count as empty-inventory dice. See [[Burners Adventure Game]].

Company seats buy packing, Fuel, Initiative, Manage, and **Boss-player control** of that hand — not a different XP track.

Non-Bosses may still hire for coin. Without Muster they do not split Company seats and do not gain Company-slot Initiative.

Hirelings

Find them in the fiction: a tavern notice, a dockside crew, a debt called in. Reaction roll (see [[Burners Referee Guide]]); Heart on the roll if you have it. Generous purse eases it; bad name hardens it.

Track level usually stays at hire (**1** — Sword or Craft, 2 Traits, half HP). **Loyalty 6**. They may gain the **loyal** tag (Loyalty 6+3 = **9**, act loyally) without becoming delvers.

Pay the weekly rate on [[Burners Equipment#Hirelings]]. **Will not enter dangerous places** — no barrow, no delve. Camp, wall, town, road. Food, lodging, and new gear are on you. **No XP**.

Retainers

A **retainer** is on **keep** — standing hand, still coin. Half-power sheet; usually starts **level 1** and **climbs on XP**. They delve and fight; by default they **put themselves first**. **Loyalty 7**. Field them at Muster (**1 seat**). Signatures $\leq \lfloor \text{Approach} / 2 \rfloor$ per Approach. Want keep and at least a half-share of treasure.

XP: Delving retainers take XP **as in OSE** (share the pot, keep half) — Mustering or not.

Loyal. When the bond is real (Referee's call), tag them **loyal**: +3 Loyalty, act loyally when they hold, keep and half-share as the bond asks. Same sheet and XP. The tag can fall if you abuse them — word travels.

Starter (Boss). A starting Boss begins with one **loyal retainer** at level 1: Sword 1 or Craft 1, 2 Traits, HP = $\lfloor 1d6 / 2 \rfloor$ (min 1), Loyalty **10** (7+3), basic kit, keep and a share of the take.

Morale (OSE-style)

The Referee calls **Morale** when nerve would break — unexpected peril in a fight, a horror rising, a comrade cut down, wages long overdue — and often **after an adventure** (will they stay on?).

Loyalty check: roll **2d6**. If the roll is $\leq$ **the hand's Loyalty** (with modifiers), they **hold**. If higher, they **break** — flee, freeze, drop the torch, demand to leave, or refuse further employment after the job. Play it by fiction.

Base Loyalty: hireling **6**, retainer **7**. **Loyal** tag: **+3**.

Common modifiers (Referee's call, as in OSE):

Situation	Typical mod
Well kept (food, water, fair share, decent treatment)	+1
Neglected (shorted pay/share, cold, mistreated)	-1 or -2
Boss leading from the front / sharing the risk	+ Boss's Heart
Boss down, fled, or absent	-2
Overwhelming foe or sudden disaster	-1 or -2
Generous treasure promised or just paid	+1

A **loyal** hand who holds **acts loyally** — they prioritize their patron over their own skin when the fiction allows. An ordinary retainer who holds still looks to their own hide first.

Without a Boss, the Referee may still check Loyalty against the base score with situational mods only.

Mercenaries (garrison)

Soldiers-for-hire for walls, camps, and armies — not barrow companions. Hire by the month; food and basic kit in the rate; wages double in wartime.

Troop	gp / month	Troop	gp / month
Peasant levy	1	Archer	5
Light footman	2	Light horseman / longbowman	10
Heavy footman	3	Medium horseman / mounted archer	15
Crossbowman	4	Heavy horseman	20

Their Morale is their own score (6 levy up to 9 mounted), checked on 2d6 as OSE. A Boss on the field may apply Heart and care mods as for company hands.

Becoming a Burner

A company hand becomes a full **Burner** only when they become a **PC**. Until then they stay on the half-power track.

On that claim: **PC at their current track level**. Rebuild under full PC rules — 4 Traits per level, full HP, full Approach math, one Signature per Approach level, open Approaches.

Professional Adventurers

The Referee may field a rare **professional adventurer**: an NPC built as a PC. Uncommon. Not a company upgrade path.

Example Hands

All examples use half power (round down) unless a Boss **manages** them that round. Each Mustering hand costs 1 Company seat.

Cob — lantern bearer (hireling)

- **Level 1, Craft 1.** HP $\lceil 1d6/2 \rceil$ (min 1). Loyalty 6.
- **Traits (2):** *lantern-bearer, quiet* (Craft).
- **Kit:** hooded lantern, flask of oil, flint and steel, spare torch.
- Will not enter the barrow.

Merrin — packbearer (hireling)

- **Level 1, Craft 1.** HP $\lceil 1d6/2 \rceil$ (min 1). Loyalty 6.
- **Traits (2):** *packbearer, broad-backed* (Craft).
- **Kit:** rope, waterskins, spare rations, room for the haul.
- Camp and road only.

Joss — fighting man (hireling)

- **Level 1, Sword 1.** HP $\lceil 1d6/2 \rceil$ (min 1). Loyalty 6 (−1 or −2 if shorted on the fee).
- **Traits (2):** *spear, leather* (Sword).
- **Kit:** spear, leather (AC 1), short blade.
- Walls and gates — not the dark below.

Bren — shield bearer (retainer)

- **Level 1, Sword 1.** HP $\lceil 1d6/2 \rceil$ (min 1). Loyalty 7 (+1 well kept / −1 neglected).
- **Traits (2):** *shield-bearer, steady* (Sword).
- **Kit:** two heaters, spare buckler, leather.
- Puts self first; climbs on XP.

Tam — squire (retainer)

- **Level 1, Sword 1.** HP $\lceil 1d6/2 \rceil$ (min 1). Loyalty 7.
- **Traits (2):** *squire, arming sword* (Sword).
- **Kit:** master's spare blade, oil, strap kit.
- Proud of the harness; looks to his own skin when the line bucks.

Rook — war dog (loyal retainer)

- **Level 1.** Sword 1. HP $\lceil 1d6/2 \rceil$ (min 1). Loyalty 10 (7+3 loyal).
- **Traits (2):** *bite, thick hide* (Sword).
- **Kit:** collar, scars, mean bark.

- Bonded after the fen job. When Morale holds, acts loyally. Sleeps on the Boss's blanket.

Nell — spear (loyal retainer)

- **Level 1, Sword 1.** HP 11d6/21 (min 1). Loyalty **10** (7+3 loyal).
 - **Traits (2):** *spear, steady under fire* (Sword).
 - **Kit:** spear, gambeson (AC 2), kettle helm.
 - Starter bond for a green Boss. Keep, half-share. When she holds, she prioritizes the Boss.
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You don't give your strength away. You make others braver than they have any right to be, and lead them somewhere they'll probably regret.